

Sita of Ur

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Sita of Ur

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Summary

Helen is often maligned as an unfaithful woman who ran away with another man, causing the deaths of thousands in the Trojan War. But what if she never did? What if the whole thing was made up by foolish men and envious gods, and the War was fought for nothing, the real Helen never went to Troy at all? This is the scenario Euripides paints in *Helen*: that the Trojan War (and all other wars by extension) was meaningless, fought over a fantasy, because the real Helen was in Egypt all along, waiting faithfully for her husband.

In *Sita of Ur*, I have followed Euripides to tell the story of how the real Sita never went to Lanka, was never taken by Ravana; instead, she was taken across the Ocean to the Mesopotamian city of Ur, home to the Priestess Enheduanna, the world's oldest poet. There, she served as one of the naditu women cloistered in the Temple of Nanna, free from interference by men.

But Sargon, King of Sumer and Akkad and the world's first Emperor, noticed Sita. Used to always get what he wants, Sargon was determined to marry her, and so moved to Ur to harrass Sita into leaving the Temple. But like Menelaos, Rama her husband would soon arrive, blown by fierce winds across the Oceans of the world.

Act I - The Sorrows Of Sita

Characters

Sita daughter of Janak of Mithila

Merchant An Indian, trader in gold and precious stones

Chorus of Sumerian women, companions of Sita and Enheduanna

Rama husband of Sita and Prince of Ayodhya

Old Woman portress at the palace

Lakshman Rama's brother

Enheduanna daughter of Sargon, High Priestess of Ur and inspired prophetess

Sargon King of Sumer and Akkad, ruler of Ur

Messenger servant of Sargon

Hanuman companion of Rama, now a god

Act I – The Sorrows of Sita

The scene is in the Mesopotamian city of Ur, in the royal district, a massive enclosure of mudbrick walls whose bricks are faced with lapis lazuli.

*The stage building represents the front of Sargon's royal palace, with central double doors. To the left of the stage is the substantial structure of the Temple of Nanna, where **Sita** serves as naditu priestess. Sita is found center-stage.*

Sita. Here by the waters of the Euphrates stand the oldest of all cities, established by Inanna when she taught us women to sow and plant and harvest. On the banks of this sacred river once a priestess, told to expose her child for her goddess bore no children, sent her infant son downstream, floating in a woven basket. A gardener of the lands of Akkad found him and named him Sargon, šarru-ukīn, for he was destined to become the greatest of all the Kings of the earth.

And indeed Sargon was not content to follow in his adoptive father's humble footsteps. He raged across the plains of Sumer like a roaring bull, fighting battle after battle until all the cities of the Euphrates were his, the First Emperor the world had ever seen. He married Tashlultum, a woman of Akkad, and she bore him many sons, but also a daughter, apple of her mother's eye. This girl Tashlultum named Enheduanna, for she was destined to be a high priestess, blessed by the goddess with understanding of all things that are and are to come.

My own home country, though, is pretty well known, for it's India, and my father was Janak King of Mithila – or at least, he's the only father I've ever known. There's an old story that Mother Earth herself gave birth to me, fatherless and unprompted, and that Janak and his wife, out riding, found me in a furrow in the earth – which may or may not be true. My name is Sita.

Now let me tell you my sad history. When I came of age, I married a man who was also a god. So kind he was, so wise, the embodiment of love itself; and all his citizens loved him. But our happiness must have drawn the envy of heaven. For Kaikeyi, his father's third wife, grew jealous, and exiled my kind prince to the dark Forest for fourteen years. I followed him, as any faithful wife should; and there I caught the eye of Ravana, King of Lanka, greatest of all cities; who was so powerful that the King of the Gods himself went in fear of him.

Ravana quitted his palace of gold and lapis and came to the Forest to seize me; but Indra, King of the Gods, disgruntled by his many defeats at Ravana's hands, deprived his rival's solid hope of all substance: he put in Ravana's path not the real me, but a living likeness conjured out of air, so that believing he possesses me he possesses only his belief. Then Indra compounded these misfortunes with new plans; for in order to rid himself of Ravana's threat to his heavenly gates, and to rid the earth of her plethora of children, he caused a war to be fought between Rama, my husband, and Ravana, my captor.

Yet all that time the Sita who endured the siege of Lanka, the Sita whom the men of Ayodhya and Kishkindha fought to rescue, was me only in name. For I myself was wrapped in a cloud, hurried through pockets of air in Indra's fiery chariot and set down here in Ur by the banks of

the Euphrates – proof that Indra did not forget me; indeed he chose the most civilized of cities to help me keep my marriage bed unstained. And here I have been, while my unhappy husband, bent on recovering me, mustered an army of Forest folk and rode to do battle with Lanka. Men died for me in the thousands, and I, the passive sufferer in it all, have heard from Enheduanna who knows all things that Rama has since declared me anathema; for it seemed to the world that I had betrayed him, living as long as I had in his enemy's house.

Then why do I go on living? For this reason: I have it on the authority of Indra himself that once my husband learns the truth – that never did I go to Lanka, never was I unfaithful – I shall live with him again by the banks of the Sarayu.

***Sita** moves left across the stage to stand by the Temple of Nanna.*

Sita. In the early days of my stay here, I was immune from suitors. I became a priestess in the cloister of this Temple, where I lived with other women who were sacred to the god. But it seems I am fated to catch the eye of powerful men. Just as once Ravana desired me, now Sargon has left his palace in Akkad and come to Ur, where he haunts me and hunts me – which is why I've come, loyal to my vows to Rama, to cast myself as a suppliant upon the Image of Nanna in his temple, to seek the god's protection from the depredations of the man. Rama in his ignorance may vilify my name; but I will ensure that my body remains free from reproach.

*Enter the **Merchant** from right of stage. He first sees and is impressed by the imposing bulk of the palace, then immediately catches sight of **Sita**.*

Merchant. Who is the lord of this imposing palace? It looks like the abode of the God of Wealth himself, hah!

*(Notices **Sita** with a start)* What's this? How is this possible? The very image of that woman whose stay in the house of her husband's enemy caused three Kingdoms to go to war! Curse you for looking like her. That woman's husband was right to reject her in the end. If I weren't a guest standing on foreign soil, I'd be tempted to kill you where you stand!

Sita. Poor man, whoever you are, please don't act like this. Why detest me because of what happened to her?

Merchant. Forgive me, it's my fault – anger got the better of me. In Ayodhya we've all heard the story; and all honest men there loathe that woman, whatever anyone says! But of course, you wouldn't know. Forgive me, lady, for the words I spoke.

Sita. Who are you, though? Where do you come from?

Merchant. I am one of Rama of Ayodhya's people.

Sita. Whoever this woman is you speak of, you must have good reason to hate her. But what brings you to the delta of the Euphrates?

Merchant. Necessity drove me from my home! I am a merchant, a trader in precious stones and jewels from the high mountains. Lanka was my main port of trade. Such a fabulous City it was! Its very streets were paved with carnelian, lapis lazuli tiled its walls. And I brought it all, in great slabs, on ships coming down the rivers of India and across the sea.

But ever since that great City fell, I have struggled to find an equally profitable market. They all regard me as an associate of Ravana's; and they fear Rama too much to do business with me. And so I have crossed the western Ocean and come here, to the lands of Sumer and Akkad, famed for their wealth and power. Perhaps I can prevail upon Sargon, that great King, to adorn his magnificent walls and temples with my precious stones.

Sita. Did you really go to the famous City of Lanka?

Merchant. Yes, and I was unfortunate enough to have seen its downfall; and my own.

Sita. Is it truly razed flat now, burned to the ground?

Merchant. So thoroughly that no trace of a wall is left.

Sita. Oh Sita, unhappy woman, for your sake the men of Lanka perished!

Merchant. And not they alone, those of Kishkindha, too!

Sita. Tell me, did they capture the woman in the end?

Merchant. Rama did, dragged her off out of the City I have heard, his eyes burning with rage.

Sita. You're only reporting hearsay. You never saw her, never saw any of this happen.

Merchant. I may not have been at the walls of Lanka, but I saw her in Ayodhya, as plainly as I see you.

Sita. Perhaps the gods made you imagine it all.

Merchant. Please talk of something else, lady. Stop harping on her.

Sita. And Rama... is he home now with his wife?

Merchant. He's certainly not in Ayodhya now – he left the city. Why and where, I do not know.

Sita. That's terrible news! For those in Ayodhya, anyway.

Merchant. He's said to have vanished, and his wife with him. Ever since Rama left, no one has seen Sita, either.

Sita. When did all this happen?

Merchant. Seven harvests have passed since we last saw either of them.

Sita. But surely Rama couldn't just disappear? He must have told his people where he was going? Some other King must have met him?

Merchant. If anyone did, I have not heard of it, nor has anyone else in Ayodhya.

Sita. And no one's had news of him since? Are you really sure?

Merchant. Not at all. Some still hold out hope; but most consider him dead.

Sita *(to herself)*. I am crushed, all my hopes are gone! *(to Merchant)*. And Janak's Queen, of Mithila – is she living?

Merchant. Sunayana, you mean? No, she died long ago.

Sita. You're not suggesting Sita's disgrace destroyed her?

Merchant. They say so. Though she was royal, she hanged herself.

Sita. And what of Rama's brothers, his companions – dead or alive?

Merchant. I've no idea. They all left Ayodhya together. No one has heard from them since. But I have heard two different rumours about another of Rama's companions, Hanuman of the Forest folk of Kishkindha.

Sita. Give me the stronger one. *(To herself)* Nothing but grief! What wrong have we done, to be so completely destroyed?

Merchant. It's said that he became a god, and that men will worship him till the end of this current world.

Sita. Those words are welcome, finally. But what's the other story?

Merchant. That grief at the rejection of Sita and the loss of Rama made him end his life in the river; and that his body was left there for the wild beasts to tear, and for the river to carry out to sea.

But enough of sad tales from the past – I'm not here to reflect upon my misery. My reason for coming to this palace is to see the High Priestess, Enheduanna. You seem to be a lady of the palace. Will you introduce me, so that I can ask the oracle how best to turn my fortunes away from all the war and death that has engulfed my country? For a wise sage told me that I shall settle here along the banks of this river, and exchange the Sarayu for the Euphrates.

Sita. You'll find Enheduanna in the Temple. But sir, make your getaway from this place before Sargon sees you – he's left his capital of Akkad and has come here to Ur. He's away at the moment, bloodily slaughtering innocent animals with his chariots and his pack of hounds – but any Indian caught here he puts to death. Don't ask me why, I'm saying nothing; and

anyway, what good would it do you to know why you're killed, once Sargon's spear is at your throat?

Merchant. Kind and frank words, which I appreciate, lady. May you be richly rewarded! Your similarity to Sita is clearly only skin-deep; inside, you're pure and faithful, not a bit like her. Wherever she is, whatever the reason we don't see her anymore – I hope she's dead. But you – good luck be with you all your life!

Exit Merchant right.

Sita. To what spirit of music shall I appeal, what song could be so bitter, to match the burden of sorrow I feel? O maidens of the Temple, cease your happy song, strike up a sad accompaniment: some grim, despairing strain in sympathy with my sufferings, in harmony with my pain. And I shall sing a chant of blood, a black paeon rising in unison with the tears I now let fall for all those dead and gone.

The Chorus of Sumerian women enters left.

Chorus. What is going on here? We were drying our clothing in the sun beside the pool when we heard a pitiful crying – no song fit for a Temple, but anguished, haunting screams like those of a demoness, seeking her lost children.

Sita. Women of Sumer, servants of the Temple, I have news for you. An Indian merchant has come ashore, one from my own country; but he has brought me only more tears. Lanka is a smoking ruin of war, destroyed by my deadly face – or rather, by my ill-used name. My mother has put a noose around her neck for shame of me. My husband and all his brothers are lost, lost at sea, taken by the Ocean and gone forever. And Hanuman of Kishkindha, my husband's close friend, will never, never be seen again: some hopeful men say he became a god, but more likely he threw himself in the river when my husband vanished at sea.

Chorus. Lady, you were given a mocking gift, a life not to be borne, when the earth brought you into the world in that furrow where you were found. Because since then, what sufferings have you not undergone? Your mother is dead, your native land is far away, hidden from your eyes; throughout the cities of India there runs a rumour that implies you slept in your enemy's embrace; your husband and his beloved brothers are all corpses on the sea bed; never again will you return to the banks of the Sarayu.

Sita. Tell me, women of Sumer, which god or goddess did Rama and I offend, all those years ago? Which jealous divinity inspired my mother Kaikeyi's servant with hate? Because of her I went to the Forest; because of her I caught Ravana's eye; because of her Lanka lies in ashes, and the peace of my hearth is shattered forever.

And then Indra, that great King of the Gods, came down in his chariot and took me away, caught me while I was gathering lotus flowers in the pools of the Forest. He snatched me and brought me, across the Ocean through the glittering sky, to this bleak land – beautiful, yes,

but bleak for me! And now, here by the flow of the Euphrates, I am soiled with a false shame that is mine only in name, only in name.

Chorus. You have suffered a lot. But one must bear the burdens of life as lightly as one can.

Sita. Don't try to comfort me! Wasn't I born a monster, every event of my entire wretched life unnatural, from the furrow in the earth to the Forest to Indra's chariot? All men call me beautiful. If only that beauty of mine could be erased, wiped clean like a picture wiped from a wall and painted over with something more human, less alluring. Then perhaps Ravana would not have noticed me. Then the people of my country would see my better side, not my worse one.

When a person suffers only one misfortune, it's hard, but bearable. But in my case, evil presses me on all sides. In the first place, I'm both innocent and slandered – and being saddled with crimes one did not commit cuts so much deeper than facing just punishment for one's own. On top of that, the King of the Gods himself uprooted me from my own country and put me down here, in a strange land, cut off from all I knew and loved.

And my sole anchor in this sea of troubles, the hope that one day I might see my husband again and convince him that I was ever faithful to him, now has been shattered by the awful news this merchant has brought. Dead, too, is Janak's Queen, the only mother I've ever known, and I'm supposed to have "destroyed" her – untrue of course, but the accusation sticks. And worst of all: even if I did somehow cross the Ocean to go home, they'd bar the gates – thinking I'm the Sita all the rumours are about, the woman whose husband rejected her after she lived in his enemy's house, the woman for whose sake so many lost their lives.

Now, I don't believe for a moment that Rama would reject me if he saw me – no, not him, he'd recognize me and know that I'm faithful, but he's dead, dead on the sea floor somewhere, and I'll never see him again. Why am I even still alive, o Sumerian women, tell me that! I could choose marriage, of course, settle down in Ur or in Akkad with the great Sargon, King of the Universe, as my husband. Perhaps you'd say that is the wisest course: be Empress of the World with Sargon, rather than live in misery in a Temple. But I could never forget Rama; and when a husband's hateful to a wife she hates even the richest house.

Yet just like Ravana, Sargon will not let me be, would disregard even the sanctity of his own Temple for the sake of my beauty. The beauty that is a blessing to other women, has been nothing but a curse to me.

Chorus Leader. Sita, don't be so sure that everything that merchant said was true! He told you himself, he wasn't even there at Lanka, and he himself doesn't know where Rama went.

Sita. But he made it clear enough. Rama's dead, I have no hope left!

Chorus Leader. The spoken word can often turn out false. Perhaps he was simply mistaken?

Sita. It can be true as well!

Chorus Leader. You're biased towards the dark view. The hopeful view could just as easily be true!

Sita. It's fear that grips me – I can only think of fearful things.

Chorus Leader. How much goodwill do you have inside the palace?

Sita. They're all my friends, Enheduanna especially – all except Sargon, that is, my pursuer, my new Ravana.

Chorus Leader. Listen, do this. Leave this sanctuary.

Sita. What? And be helpless prey to Sargon? What are you trying to say?

Chorus Leader. Leave this sanctuary, and go see Enheduanna in her palace! She knows all things, and moreover, she's your friend. Ask her whether your husband is still alive, she'll know for sure. Then, once you know the answer, weep or rejoice. What's the point in weeping now, when you don't even know for sure? I'll go with you, if that makes it easier. Women should always support one another.

Sita. Yes, I'll do that. Let's go to Enheduanna's palace, in the complex beyond the Temple.

Chorus. We'll all join you, Sita!

Sita. But then it'll be settled, it'll really be true. O, what words of horror or misery am I about to hear?

Chorus. Don't play the prophetess of your own woe, Sita. Don't jump ahead to horrors when you haven't even heard them yet.

Sita. Even if he's alive, what deep distress has Rama suffered? Or does he really lie dead on the sea floor?

Chorus. Accept the future, whatever face it may wear, as a friend.

Sita. O Sarayu, my home river, sweet-running and sparkling blue, to you I appeal. Be my witness. If the report is true, and my husband is dead, I shall...

Chorus. What wild words are you saying now?

Sita. I shall take my own life. I'll noose my neck with a rope, like my mother did; or use the bloody knife, till the sharp, cold thrust of bronze finally ends my suffering. My death shall be a sacrifice to whatever divinity decided to curse me with this beauty.

Chorus. May you know only hope, lady! May bad luck finally leave you!

Sita. O pitiful Lanka, destroyed by a deed of mine that was never done! My beauty has borne a monstrous child, of agony piled on agony, blood piled on tears, sorrow piled on sorrow. Countless mothers mourn their sons, countless Lankan girls are now the sisters of corpses. Other women have suffered for their beauty, it is true; suffered bad marriages to bad men. But my beauty has burned cities, and been the death of so many men.

Act II - Rama Comes To Sumer

Chapter Summary

Rama, after a shipwreck which only himself and his brothers survive, arrives in the Euphrates Delta. Leaving his brothers to guard what remains of their ship, he enters Ur looking for provisions, not knowing what city or country he is in; and here he meets Sita.

Sita and the Chorus exit the stage through the central doors of the palace, in order to consult Enheduanna. Rama enters right; he is in rags, looking more dead than alive, a piece of torn sailcloth wrapped round him as covering. He has come from the marshes of the Euphrates Delta, having been shipwrecked in the swamps of Mesopotamia.

Rama. Dasaratha, my father, so long and hard you prayed for sons; it would have been better for you had your prayer never been answered. I led an impossible army against Ravana, the likes of which the world had never seen before; I built an impossible bridge of floating rock across which we rode our chariots into Lanka. My authority owed nothing to compulsion, but was based on willing obedience, even love, from the men I led. My dear brothers never envied me; even when I returned to take up Kingship of Ayodhya, my brothers willingly stepped aside, happy to have me rule.

And now, the count of all the dead of Lanka has been made – all except my brothers and I, for we are lost at sea, neither dead nor alive. When I sacked the towers of Lanka I celebrated, and went home in triumph with Sita my wife by my side, rescued from Ravana's grasp.

At first, I was happy; but my people began to murmur. She had spent too much time in my enemy's house, they said; no woman could have resisted Ravana's charms. Soon, the rumours turned against me, for allowing her to stay; I was disrespected in my own city! And to my eternal sorrow, I admit I became convinced by the rumours myself. In my darkest moment, I sent Lakshman my brother to take Sita into the Forest, the Dandaka Forest where we had dwelt for fourteen years, and there to kill her. But this my people do not know – that before ever Lakshman had a chance to lay a hand on Sita, she vanished, dissolved into the air before my eyes.

I knew then that the Sita I had rescued, the Sita for whose sake Lanka fell and Ravana threw himself into destruction, was never real. She was a mere phantom, an illusion, wrought by who knows what god. I knew also that the real Sita was not with me, but must have been taken somewhere else, in secret, by one surely even more powerful than Ravana; and so I left Ayodhya that same day, taking my brothers with me, telling no one where I went or why.

For seven years I traversed the length and width of India looking for Sita, but I did not find her. Finally I put out to the western sea, intending to search the whole world for my beloved; but I found disaster instead. And now I'm here, my men lost – for only my brothers and myself survived the wreck – our ship destroyed by the waves, washed up on this coast. I found a floating keel, all that was left, on which in my desperate danger I got to land. Who the inhabitants are, or what this place is called, I've no idea.

Though I'm at the end of my tether – no food, not even clothes to cover me, for all can see that I'm wearing nothing but torn sails saved from the wreck – I still feel responsible for my brothers. I have brought them here into this disaster with me. And so I have gone out to try and scrounge provisions, and perhaps find us a way home. When I saw these high walls I thought it must be some King's palace, or perhaps a temple which will give aid to sailors in need.

(Rama has been approaching the palace doors during the last lines of his speech). Hello there! Is there a porter around, or anyone to announce me?

*(As he knocks, an irritable **Old Woman** appears at the doors, and squints at **Rama**, clearly nearsighted. She is the portress of Sargon's palace).*

Old Woman. Who's this at the door? Stop your banging, or you'll end up dead! You look Indian. We've no truck with Indians.

Rama *(taken aback)*. Well said, lady, a fine speech! I'll behave myself, only please – a bit less temper!

Old Woman. I'm telling you, make yourself scarce! I've strict orders from the King himself not to allow any Indian inside the palace.

*(She moves threateningly towards **Rama**, her hand raised to strike him).*

Rama. Please, there's no need for violence!

Old Woman. No need, is there? Then do as I say!

Rama. Would you at least announce to your master that I'm here? Perhaps he's not as angry as you think. Surely he'd not turn away a man in need?

Old Woman. I won't be at all popular if I do. Off with you; go try some other house if you have to.

Rama. I can't, I have nowhere else to go!

Old Woman. You're being a nuisance, you know. You'll just get thrown out.

Rama. To think I had an army once, and marched straight across the sea on a bridge of floating rock!

Old Woman. You may have been someone elsewhere; here you're nobody.

Rama (*his eyes tearing up*). What have I done to you, to deserve this?

Old Woman. Tears in your eyes, eh? What are you moaning for?

Rama. Only the happy days I used to know.

Old Woman. Then go cry to your old friends. Don't bother me with it.

Rama. What country am I in, anyway? And whose palace is this? At least tell me that.

Old Woman (*pointing to the front of the Temple of Nanna*). You're in Ur, the City sacred to Nanna-Sin! This is his Temple, the centre of our City.

Rama. Ur, in Sumer? So it's an ill wind that blew me here.

Old Woman. And what do you have against the plains of the Euphrates, you stranger?

Rama. Nothing, lady. I'm merely cursing my own luck, having been blown by the wind so far from my home.

Old Woman. Plenty of folk have troubles, young man. You're hardly the first.

Rama. Your King, whatever you call him – is he at home?

Old Woman. Akkad is his home; but he stays here in Ur these days.

Rama. Then where is he? Inside the house?

Old Woman. He's not at home. And he's a hater of all Indians these days.

Rama. And to what do my people and I owe such passion?

Old Woman. Haven't you heard? Sita, daughter of Janak, serves in this Temple.

Rama (*shocked*). What? Did I hear you right? Say that again!

Old Woman. Sita, the one who's blamed for the fall of Lanka.

Rama. But where did she come from? How can she be here? Explain it to me!

Old Woman (*exasperated*). From India of course! She came from her country to ours, flying through the sky. A god brought her to our shores.

Rama. But when?

Old Woman. Before ever any warriors went to Lanka, friend. But make yourself scarce! You're a good lad, but you've come at a bad time. There appears to be some upset in the palace, and if my royal master catches you here, your welcome will be death. Listen, I do mean well for you, more than I let on. If I spoke harshly, it was only fear of Sargon that made me do it.

Exit Old Woman into the palace. Rama is left alone, outside, staring after her.

Rama (to himself). I'm at a loss. I know the Sita I took home to Ayodhya was a false one. But could Sita be here, so far away? How did she cross the sea? That old woman said a god brought her – surely my Sita is innocent, surely my people and I were wrong to condemn her and she has not simply run away with some rival of Ravana's, be he god or man! No, it cannot be. It must be some other woman with the same name. But she called her daughter of Janak – perhaps there is another lord named Janak somewhere.

But the old woman also said she came from India – could there be another Janak, another Mithila, for this woman to have come from? I don't know what to make of it. But the earth is vast – many things must share a name, cities, countries, and women, too. And anyway, I will not be frightened off by this old woman's behaviour. Whatever the customs are in this country, it looks like a civilized place; and the lands of Sumer and Akkad are famous for their culture. No man from a great city such as this could be so barbaric as to deny help to a shipwrecked husband, looking only for his wife.

I will not hide; I shall wait here for Sargon's return. If he turns out savage after all, or evil, I will escape and make my way back to my brothers; but if he shows any sign of virtue or care for his fellow man, I'll ask for supplies to meet our needs, then continue my search for Sita.

The Chorus re-enters centre stage, through the palace doors. Rama remains outside, partly concealed behind a buttress of the Temple of Nanna.

Chorus. We have heard her! We've heard Enheduanna speak her prophecy! And her message was clear: that Rama has not gone to his grave beneath the glimmering dark waves, but has been a wanderer, driven by the winds from his natives shores and cast up here, at the mouth of the river, caught in the reeds and the swamps; he and his brothers, miserable, hungry, and far from friends.

Sita re-enters centre through the palace doors. She begins to move towards the Temple of Nanna.

Sita (to herself). Now I can return to my station in the Temple without upsetting the other priestesses with my tears. My fears are finally put to rest! Enheduanna gave me the revelation I never dared hope for: that my husband is alive, and that, after wandering the Oceans of the world, he'll find the end of his sufferings right here, in Ur.

The only thing that still worries me is this: will Rama be spared when he arrives? Sargon is determined to have me for himself, and because he fears either my husband or male relatives of mine coming to Ur to claim me, he has every Indian he sees put to death. Enheduanna never told me what Sargon will do to Rama when he arrives; and I was too distracted to ask. But she did say that he's survived a shipwreck with his brothers, and is nearby. O dear husband, when will you come? And if you come, what a void in my heart you'll fill!

***Sita** catches sight of **Rama**, hidden beside the Temple entrance, and hurries to him. Just as Rama could not believe that his wife was truly here in Ur, Sita dares not believe that Rama has really arrived, and so initially reacts with extreme caution.*

Sita (*alarmed*). Who is this man? What are you doing here? This is some scheme by that sacrilegious man Sargon, isn't it? He has no shame, sending some savage servant of his to grab me and drag me to him!

(She tries to run into the Temple, but is stopped by Rama)

Rama. Stop! Why are you running? Don't run away. When you revealed your face it struck me speechless with astonishment.

Sita (*calling to the **Chorus** for help*). Friends, women of Sumer, help me! There's a savage man here barring my way to the sanctuary. He wants to seize me and let Sargon take me by force!

Rama. I'm no bandit or mercenary! I'm not here to abduct you!

Sita. You sure look like a desperate bandit, dressed in those rags.

Rama. If only you'd stand still and look at me. Stop darting away, please, don't be afraid.

Sita (*grasping hold of the Temple doors*). Very well, now that I'm holding on to the Temple so you cannot seize me, I'll stand still if you like.

Rama. Lady, who are you?

Sita. I might as well ask you the same.

Rama. I've never before seen such a resemblance –

Sita. To what? What do you mean?

Rama. Are you native to this country?

Sita. No. My home lies in India. But until today, I feared I'd never return there. And you? I long to know as well.

Rama. Lady, you look uncannily like Sita.

Sita. And you like Rama. What does it mean?

Rama. The truth. I am that unhappy man.

Sita (*recognition finally dawning on her, her eyes lighting up*). ...It's you, it's really you, isn't it? My Rama, who I feared so long was dead on the sea floor, returned to me today! O long-lost husband, come to your wife's arms!

Rama (*still cautious, not yet convinced the woman before him is truly Sita*). What do you mean – wife? Stay away from me. I am faithful to only one woman. If you're not my Sita, I'll have nothing to do with you.

Sita. The wife that Janak, my father, gave you.

Rama (*to himself*). Why must I be tormented by such cruel visions?

Sita. I am no vision, no ghost, no illusion made of air.

Rama. No more than I am the husband of two women, lady.

Sita. Who is this other woman whose husband you are?

Rama. The wife whom I thought I had rescued from Lanka, but was taken elsewhere instead.

Sita. Rama, I am your wife. You have no other queen.

Rama (*to himself*). My mind seems clear enough; but do my eyes deceive me?

Sita. Surely you recognize the wife who lived with you in the Forest for so many years?

Rama. You look like her for sure, I won't deny that.

Sita. And if you don't trust your own eyes, what will you put your faith in?

Rama. Perhaps... but no, it cannot be! No. My eyes deceive me, lady. Some other King of some other city took my Sita. She cannot have been living here in this Temple all this time, across the Ocean. My eyes fail me, lady. I have another wife; and you cannot be her.

Sita. But I never left you, in the Forest. Not to Lanka, nor anywhere else. Only a phantom did.

Rama. I know that a phantom went to Lanka. But who could create such a thing?

Sita. Indra formed her out of air, to be Ravana's prey.

Rama. You were here then, and in Lanka, at the same time?

Sita. A name can travel where a body can't.

Rama (*deeply conflicted*). No. Leave me alone. I had troubles enough before.

Sita. Will you leave me, then, to go and live with your shadow-wife?

Rama. Even the shadow is no more. I'll go and find a ship again, to continue my search for Sita in more reasonable places. Farewell, lady. And good luck, since you look so much like my unhappy Sita.

Sita. Please, don't destroy me like this! A husband found – and lost!

Rama. I am sorry for your pain, lady; but it is nothing compared to my grief at finding my wife a phantom in my arms after waging war to rescue her. I'm not about to fall for another phantom. Farewell.

Sita. Was ever a woman so unhappy? The first ray of hope I see after seven years, and it is dashed before my eyes. I will never see my home again.

***Lakshman** enters right, agitated and out of breath. He intercepts **Rama**, who is about to turn away; but he has not yet noticed **Sita**, who stands weeping, facing the Temple wall.*

Lakshman. Rama! I've been wandering all over this swamp looking for you! Finding you has been hard work.

Rama. What happened? These people haven't robbed the wreck, have they?

Lakshman (*astonishment in his voice after noticing Sita*). Daughter of Janak! You've been here, then. How? And for how long?

Sita. I've been here before ever you went to make war on Lanka. I'm innocent of whatever I am accused of doing in Ravana's house!

Lakshman (*with mounting anger and frustration*). I know full well that you weren't in Lanka; I myself saw the phantom we took home. But this far away, all on your own, just to virtuously escape Ravana? I remember how hard it was to cross even the sea to Lanka, let alone this faraway country, and with no army to help you! I was unaware that you'd sprouted wings. Did some rakshasa fly you across the sea, lady? Ravana himself, perhaps, knowing that his citadel would fall?

(*To Rama*). It seems we're done here, brother. Let's find ourselves a ship, take this woman back with us, and go. Her unfaithfulness has kept us from home long enough. Her fate is yours to decide once we return to Ayodhya; but after all the trouble she's given us, I stand by your earlier decision to have her killed.

Rama (*paying no attention to Lakshman, his eyes fixed intently on Sita*). At last, the answer! It's really true, you really are her!

***Rama** embraces **Sita**; **Lakshman** looks on in surprise.*

Sita. Rama, dearest of all in the world, we have both grown old waiting. But now our joy is as fresh and as bright as it was on the day we were married!

(To the Chorus). Women of Sumer, I have my husband again! Finally he has returned to me, to love and to cherish for all the rest of my days.

Rama. And I've found you. There's so much to tell, so much to share...! Where do I even start?

Sita. I am happy at last, after so many years of darkness! For the first time since I was taken from the Forest I shed tears not of sorrow, but of joy!

Rama. Dearest Sita, how did I even find fault in you? The daughter of the Earth herself is mine again, is mine! And now the god who stole you away from me, there in the dark Forest, is leading us on to better things.

Sita. Lucky misfortune, dear husband, has brought us together after a long, long storm that began long back in Ayodhya; now it is finally time for us to enjoy the weather.

Rama. May you enjoy it – and I likewise. With two like us, we share everything; joy and sorrow cannot be separated, but we will share it all.

Sita *(to Chorus).* Dear friends, I no longer regret the past. I have my husband again, he belongs to me after the many years I waited – o, how I waited and never gave up hope!

Rama. And to think I believed you were unfaithful to me. But tell me, how did you steal away from the Forest that day, before Ravana came to take you?

Sita. A cruel question, probing back to a cruel day.

Rama. Nevertheless, I must know! All should hear what truly happened, and come to believe in your innocence.

Sita *(agitated again).* I spit away the words I have to speak. I never chose any of this; I would have died before leaving you.

Rama *(kindly).* For my sake, try to say it. Speaking plainly of old pain makes one feel better once it's done.

Sita. I never entered that rakshasa's house. His hands never touched me; I never shared his bed, his lust.

Rama. What god or power was it, though, that brought you here across the sea?

Sita. It was Indra who came, decoyed me, and brought me to the Euphrates in his chariot.

Rama. Incredible... and why? What was his reason?

Sita. Indra had long hated Ravana for the humiliation and defeat he suffered at Ravana's hands. He wished to deny the rakshasa lord the prize he wanted; but since he also feared that

Ravana would once again lay siege to his city of Amravati if he merely spirited me away, Indra created a decoy image of me to trick Ravana into believing he had got his prize.

Rama. So it was also Indra, who supplied the phantom image I found in my arms in Ayodhya.

Sita. Yes. But there is more grief still. My mother, my adoptive mother in Mithila –

Rama. Queen Sunayana?

Sita. She is dead.. Believing in my disgrace, she killed herself.

Rama. Poor woman. Ravana, I thought I had defeated you, but in the end, you have ruined me. Yet you had no enjoyment of it yourself, since you were killed, along with all your brothers and your sons and so many of your people.

Sita. And I was robbed by Indra of my country, bereft of my friends; and above all, I lost you – all for a lie, for it was only my name, only my name, that earned me an adulteress's shame.

Chorus. So much misery! You two should meet only with good luck from now on, now that you've found one another again. Only that will make up for the past.

Lakshman (*bewildered*). But... isn't this Sita? Wasn't all our suffering for her sake, all because she ran away with a rakshasa?

Rama. No. The Sita we took from Lanka was a mere ghost, remember? Only a phantom stayed in Ravana's house; the real Sita never went there.

Lakshman. But how can she be here without some rakshasa having flown her, whether Ravana or some kinsman of his? Can you really believe her when she claims she was carried by a god? Couldn't Ravana, knowing that Lanka would fall, have brought her here in secret, too far away for you to ever find, with her own full knowledge?

Rama. No, my brother. I know you say such things only from love of me, not wishing me to be hurt by yet another disappointment. But this lady is my Sita, and she is faithful. Take my word for it.

Lakshman (*to Sita*). Sister, the ways of God are mysterious and hard to fathom. Some suffer and fight while others effortlessly prosper, but one day fall into ruin; for no man can hold onto fortune forever. You and your husband have had more than your share of suffering: you stood against a storm of words, he stood against a storm of arrows. And when he fought at Lanka he won nothing; yet now happiness is his, unexpected and of its own accord.

And you never shamed anyone, nor did you do what the folk of Ayodhya said you did.

Rama. We are all due for a change of luck, brother! Go and tell the others what has happened here. But tell them to be ready for battle; for I can see a trial of strength coming our way. We will not be allowed to go without a fight.

Act III - A Plan for Survival

Chapter Summary

Rama's arrival after many long years has brought a ray of hope into Sita's life. But they both know that Sargon is due back in Ur at any moment; and if he learns that Rama has entered his city the consequences will be disastrous. Sita realizes that their only hope of escape lies in the High Priestess Enheduanna, the mysterious daughter of Sargon of Akkad blessed by her Goddess with knowledge of all things. If she can be convinced to hide Rama's presence from her father, Rama and Sita have a chance to escape Mesopotamia and finally end the exile that began all those years ago in the Forest.

*Exit **Lakshman** right to pass the news on to Rama's other brothers, still waiting at the shipwreck.*

Sita. Well then, so far so good. But tell me, dear husband, tell me how you've survived since we were together in the Forest. I won't be able to change any of your sufferings, but I long to at least share your burdens I any way I can.

Rama. One single question, yet it may as well be a thousand. Must I describe our horror at seeing you dissolve before our eyes in Ayodhya, a mere phantom? The fear my brothers and I felt, that if we told the people of Ayodhya what had happened they would think me a madman and drive me from the city? The years we spent wandering all the forests, deserts, and mountains of India, and never finding you? And finally the storm that sent us across the wide open sea, no land in sight?

Were I to give you your fill of words I'd suffer in the telling the same pains I suffered then, and my sorrows would be even greater. No, better to let it remain in the past.

Sita. You are right; forgive me for asking such a dreadful question. Leave all the rest, and tell me just this: how long did you wander, looking for me?

Rama. After out fourteen years in the Forest and at Lanka, my brothers and I spent another seven wandering.

Sita. Such a long, grim time! Kaikeyi's fourteen years had seemed bad enough; but such a length of suffering is truly uncalled for. *(Her eyes fill with tears)* And now you've escaped to find me, only to be faced with death!

Rama. Death? What do you mean?

Sita. Haven't you heard? Sargon, King of Sumer and Akkad and master of this palace, means to kill you.

Rama. The old woman who guards the gate said something to that effect. But why should Sargon wish to kill me? What sort of man is he, that he puts strangers to death without even seeing them?

Sita. Your surprise arrival puts a stop to our wedding.

Rama. What? Someone here trying to marry my wife?

Sita. Yes, and he will take me by force if he has to. Not even my status as priestess, according to which I cannot be touched and may not marry, will prevent him.

Rama. So the old woman at the door was right!

Sita. What doors have you been knocking on here in Ur?

Rama (*pointing at the palace doors*). Those doors. And I was chased off like some beggar.

Sita. Well then, you know the whole story.

Rama. I do. What I don't know is how far you've foiled them.

Sita. My body and spirit have been kept chaste for you. The shelter of the Temple has protected me so far; although Sargon is willing to commit sacrilege for that sake of having me.

Rama. But how can I be sure? How can I prevent the same rumours being spread about you again, the same doubts?

Sita. Do you see these heavy Temple doors?

Rama. I do. They look more like the gate to a fortress than the doors of a Temple.

Sita. I live there as a cloistered priestess, along with other chaste women. The people of this land call us *naditu*, and our chastity is sacred to their gods.

Rama. Is this their custom, to have priestesses live inside a fortified temple?

Sita. I've been as safe as I was in the ashrams we visited in the Forest.

Rama. So I can't just carry you away right now?

Sita. You'd find a grave, rather than a home.

Rama. Then I am still the unhappiest man alive. I have found my love, only to be barred from her forever.

Sita. Escape, save yourself. Tell the people of Ayodhya that I am dead. Don't be ashamed.

Rama. And leave you? After I defeated Ravana for your sake, after wandering the forests and the ocean for seven years to find you?

Sita. Better that than to die in vain.

Rama. No. I will not listen to such cowardly advice.

Sita. I suppose you want to kill Sargon like you did Ravana. You can't.

Rama. And why not? Is his body proof against arrows? Does Sargon possess the boon of invincibility that Ravana had neglected to ask for?

Sita. You'll see. It is folly to attempt the impossible.

Rama. So I meekly surrender to this king's will?

Sita. You're cornered, and in a foreign land. We must think of some way out.

Rama. If I have to die here, I'd rather die fighting for what is right.

Sita. There's just one hope for us, one single chance.

Rama. What sort of persuasion could it be?

Sita. If Sargon never learns of your arrival –

Rama. And who's going to tell him? No one here knows me but you.

Sita. He has an ally in the Temple, one blessed by the gods.

Rama. You mean some private oracle?

Sita. I mean his daughter, the High Priestess Enheduanna.

Rama. And what will she do?

Sita. She knows all things, and though I am her friend, she is bound to Sargon by ties of blood. She will tell her father you're here.

Rama. But then I'll be killed, and with no hope of hiding.

Sita. But Enheduanna knows me, and she knows my plight. If we both appealed to her as suppliants –

Rama. To ask her what?

Sita. Not to inform her father of your presence.

Rama. Could we get away, if we won her over? Does Sargon have no other oracles, no other ways of knowing?

Sita. With Enheduanna's help, we can get away easily. Sargon entrusts this whole city to her. But in secret, without her support, no.

Rama. Since you know this Priestess, you go and convince her.

Sita. I'll get to her and ask, I promise.

Rama. But what if she won't hear you? What if she's more loyal to her father than to her friend?

Sita. Then you die, and I am miserably forced to marry Sargon.

Rama. After all that's happened – can I truly trust you, Sita? Or is your word “force” merely an excuse?

Sita. No! And to prove it, I'll swear by your own head –

Rama. Swear what? To die? To never betray me in love?

Sita. To die by the same sword that claims your life, and to burn on the same pyre.

Rama. And I, if I lose you but somehow survive, shall choose death rather than lose you again.

*The doors of the Temple begin to open, in preparation for the arrival of **Enheduanna**, High Priestess and Princess of Ur.*

Sita. O endless misery! Rama, we are trapped! Enheduanna is coming out of the Temple; I can hear the doors being opened. Run! If she sees you before I have a chance to speak to her you are lost! But what good will it do anyway? With her divine gift, she already knows you're here. She's probably coming out to tell her father of your arrival. You escaped a watery death at sea, only to be killed here. And I am ruined.

*Enter **Enheduanna** centre, solemnly, clad in the robes of a Priestess. She is preceded by two **handmaidens**, one of whom carries a bowl in which incense burns, the other a torch.*

Enheduanna (to **handmaidens**). Lead on, hold the torch up straight! Yes, wave the incense bowl around a bit more, to purify all the air in this place. If anyone with unhallowed foot has gone in my path, purify the floor with fire. Then take the fire and the incense back to the sacred flame within the sanctuary.

(To **Sita**). Well, Sita, what do you think of my prophecies now? Without his army, without his phantom wife, Rama manifestly stands before you. Unhappy man, to escape so many dangers only to end up here without even knowing what his fate will be – a sweet return home, or bitter death in Sumer.

(To **Rama**). This is the day your fate has brought you to, the day that will change your life. Just as your life changed all those years ago, when your mother Kaikeyi, inspired with envy, convinced your father to exile you; and in so doing unknowingly fulfilled your destiny.

Likewise, what happens today will decide whether you return safely home, and Sita with you, so that your people may learn that she has never lived in another man's house; or whether instead you never set out on your journey.

It lies in my power either to destroy you by telling my father of your arrival, or to save your life by keeping it hidden from him – although my strict instructions were to inform him straightaway if you reached the waters of the Euphrates.

(*To the **Chorus***). Will any of you inform Sargon of this man's arrival and ensure my safety?

*The **Chorus** does not respond; they stare at **Enheduanna** and at **Sita**, but remain motionless. None of the women of Sumer is willing to betray Sita and her long-lost love.*

Sita (*to **Enheduanna**, in supplication*). Lady, I fall to the ground in supplication, and in this humble posture, for my own sake and this man's – whom I have won back after so many years and now stand in danger of losing forever – I beg you to spare us. Save him, save us both, I ask you; don't inform your father. Don't sacrifice your piety and capacity for love to buy a bad man's gratitude.

The violence Sargon employs, against me and against my husband and all his people whom he mercilessly puts to death for no crime at all, is against God. The earth and the sky belong to all, not merely to the King of Sumer and Akkad, and Rama and I have a right to a happy married life just as much as Sargon does. I acknowledge my debt to him; in the end it proved a blessing, that Indra took me to this city to be kept safe for my husband, rather than abandon me to Ravana's lust.

But your gods as well as mine would want me returned to my own husband. Don't give more weight to a lustful father than to what is right. How can you be blessed with the knowledge of all things, yet not see the difference between good and evil? You see how much I have suffered. Please, save us, bestow your grace upon us.

You have heard my husband, and undoubtedly you know what his people have said about me. My own country hates the name of Sita. They all know me as the wife who lived happily in the house of her husband's enemy. But if I get back to Ayodhya and let them hear and see the truth – that they were deceived by a god, that I never went to Lanka – they'll restore my good name, and my husband's, too.

If Rama had been killed at the walls of Lanka, I'd have dutifully rendered my service to the dead, and been content here. But now that I have him back, alive, must he be taken from me?

Chorus Leader. Your words arouse my pity. But how will Rama himself argue to save his own life? I long to hear it.

Rama (*to **Enheduanna***). I will not weep, Priestess. I choose courage. If you have any understanding of justice, and it seems right to you to save a man who has done you no harm and seeks only to reclaim his wife, then give her back to me and let us sail in safety. If not, it won't be the first grief I've endured; but you will be seen by all to be an evil woman.

If you and your father prove evil, and steal Sita from me, I will tell you what will happen. We are bound by oath, Sita and I. If I die, so will she – and I will fight your father to the death if needed, as I fought Ravana. Neither your father nor any man alive will marry my Sita. I shall take her with me; home if I can, to the land of the dead if I must.

But why am I saying all this? If you are not persuaded yet, by justice and goodness itself, then you are evil, and nothing will persuade you; and your shame will be yours to live with.

Chorus Leader (to *Enheduanna*). Priestess, it rests with you to judge this case. Please, do not disappoint us with your judgement.

Enheduanna. By nature and vocation I love piety. I would never indulge my father's impiety at the cost of my own dishonour. In my heart there is a great shrine of Justice; I mean to keep it holy all my life. I shall keep silence. I refuse to become an accomplice to my father's wickedness. Even though it may seem that I am betraying him, by steering him away from folly I will be doing my father a favour.

As for escape, there I cannot help; you must find some way yourselves. I am sworn to the Temple of Nanna and may not leave it. I'll merely stand aside and hold my tongue.

Exit Enheduanna centre, with her retinue, back into the Temple.

Chorus Leader. The wicked never prosper; our only hope lies in doing right.

Sita. We're safe as far as she's concerned. But with your ship ruined, how will we escape?

Rama. Listen to me. You've been here a long time – do you know the palace servants well?

Sita. They're all my friends. But what is your plan?

Rama. Could you persuade one of Sargon's grooms to give us a chariot?

Sita. I could; but how would we make our way back to India by land? This place is unknown to us, and the lands in between even more so.

Rama. You're right, we can't. Then... I'll hide in the palace and kill Sargon myself! I'm sure you could persuade the palace servants to keep quiet.

Sita. Enheduanna wouldn't sanction that; she's promised to keep silent since you have done her no harm, but were you to try and kill her father she would surely cry out.

Rama. Of course... and what's more, we don't even have a ship left. And I am not willing to kill all the palace servants and guards when they come to avenge their King.

Sita. Listen – I have a plan of my own. Let me report you dead to Sargon.

Rama. It sounds ominous. But I'm willing to try anything.

Sita. Good; then I'll act like a mourner, dress in white like a widow and tear my hair, as an example for that impious man.

Rama. But how will this old-fashioned trick help us escape?

Sita. I'll tell him you were drowned at sea and ask for his permission to set up a monument.

Rama. Suppose he agrees – we still won't have a ship!

Sita. Sargon does not know any of our customs. I'll tell him that it is Indian custom to procure a ship for those who died at sea, and duly consign their belongings to the waves.

Rama. Perfect – but what if Sargon is suspicious, and orders a ceremony on land?

Sita. I'll tell him that fulfilling this one remaining duty to my dead husband will free me to marry him – he'll be so overcome with lust and happiness, he won't think of suspicion.

Rama. Another good idea! And of course, I'll join you on the ship to help with the ritual, as will my brothers.

Sita. Of course! You'll all be my dead husband's servants, loyal to him even beyond the grave.

Rama. Once I have a ship and my brothers by my side, the host of Heaven could not prevent my leaving!

Sita. You must arrange for your brothers and the weapons. I'll do the rest.

Rama. It seems our long exile is finally about to end! But who will you say told you I was dead?

Sita. You! I'll pretend you were the sole survivor of Rama's crew, and saw him drown.

Rama. Yes; and the poor state of these rags of sail I've got wrapped round me will make it believable.

Sita. They're certainly handy now, though it would be better had you never suffered such misfortune.

Rama. Shall I follow you into the palace, or would it be better for me to remain outside?

Sita. Stay here. Should Sargon get vicious, you'll have some distance between you to mount an attack. Meanwhile I'll enter the Temple, change my robes for widow's white, tear out my hair and scratch my cheeks. Now, everything hangs in the balance: either we both die, or we reach home, and I'll have saved your life.

Exit Sita into the Temple. The Chorus remains, as does Rama.

Chorus. Perched among the leafy green of olive or of oak, o sweetest and saddest of birds, you I invoke. Nightingale, nightingale, summon a note to match as I sing of unhappy Sita's tears. What is god, what is not god, what lies in between man and god? Who on this earth can claim to have been to the end of that's question's tortuous lane? For every man has seen the fates of the world lurch this way and that, from fortune to misfortune in a single word, a single day.

O Sita, given birth by Mother Earth Herself, yet from the rooftops of Ayodhya you have been proclaimed a wicked woman who shamed her husband, shamed her honour. Madmen, all who go to war for honour or glory or justice! If battle and blood are to settle the score, if death decides the difference between good and evil, right and wrong, then grief and hate will never leave the cities of men. Through strife such men have found an early grave, who might by words have settled matters for everyone, and freed themselves from the delusion of possessing you, Sita! Now they all lie dead, the men of Lanka, while you and your husband both endure a pitiable life of pain and exile.

Act IV - A Marriage Denied

Chapter Summary

In Act IV, Sargon of Akkad, King of the Universe, finally enters the scene in person. He is determined to have Sita as his wife; but this time, Sita and Rama have a plan to outwit him. Interestingly enough Sargon, and Theoklymenos in Euripides, despite being the main antagonist never comes across as quite so villainous as the other characters make him out to be. He waits years for Sita to consent to his marriage, rather than take her by force, so that his joy at finally hearing her say yes is genuine; and he is willing to spare no expense for Sita to give her former husband the funeral she wants to give him. Only once he realizes he's been betrayed in his own house does Sargon turn vicious.

*Enter **Sargon**, left. He is accompanied by **attendants** who carry hunting gear; barking hounds are kept on a leash. Sargon quickly dispatches his retinue into the palace, then walks over to the Temple of Nanna; but he soon notices that Sita is not to be found outside.*

Sargon (to **attendants**). You servants, take the dogs and the nets into the palace, where they belong.

(To himself). I've often criticized myself. I am Sargon, King of the Universe, First Emperor of the World; and yet, still criminals escape my punishments, still revolts break out in my cities. And now I discover some Indian sailor has landed here in broad daylight and given my scouts the slip – a spy no doubt, or someone trying to steal Sita from me by stealth! He's a corpse as soon as I find him!

(Noticing **Sita** is not sitting at the doors of the Temple, her usual spot). It seems I've arrived too late. The plot's accomplished. There's no one here – the daughter of Janak has left, smuggled out of the country!

***Sargon** bangs on the doors of the palace; **servants** appear and disappear to do his bidding.*

Sargon. Open the doors! Get the chariots ready! My bride shall not escape so easily!

*Re-enter **Sita**, left, from the Temple.*

Sargon (astonished). Wait! She's still here, in the Temple. She hasn't got away. Why do you hide from me, Sita? And – you've changed your clothes! You look like a ghost now, in that white robe. And why have you torn out your hair and scored your cheeks with your nails?

What happened? Has a dream, and evil oracle, got you into this state? Or have you had bad news from home?

Sita. My lord – as I must call you now – I am lost. My hopes are dead.

Sargon. What happened? What sort of trouble are you in?

Sita. My Rama, the husband I have waited for all these desperate years, is dead.

Sargon. That is hopeful news for me, though I cannot rejoice seeing you in this state. Did Enheduanna tell you?

Sita. Yes – and a witness too, a man of his ship who saw him die.

Sargon. Ah, somebody who can vouch for the death of my rival, then – is he here?

Sita. He's here, all right; but I wish he had never come!

Sargon. Who is he, and what was his role on the ship? What does he say he saw? I want the facts.

Sita. He's right there, cowering in fear of you beside the Temple doors.

Sita points to Rama, who is once again partially hidden by the massive fortifications of the Temple Gate and gives his best impression of cringing in terror.

Sargon. By the gods, what a sight! The man's in rags!

Sita. Alas, my poor husband must have looked as wretched, when he died.

Sargon. Who is this man? Where did he come here from?

Sita. He's an Indian sailor, who sailed with my husband.

Sargon. And how does he say Rama died?

Sita. The saddest death – drowned in the open sea.

Sargon. What wild waters was he voyaging in?

Sita. The winds blew his ship across the Ocean that separates the earth from the waters below.

Sargon. And how come this man here survived?

Sita. Sometimes the lowborn are luckier than the Kings of the world.

Sargon. Where did he leave the shipwreck? Where did it land?

Sita. Where I hope it may rot. (*to herself*) Forgive me, Rama.

Sargon. Rama is dead, woman. What boat did this fellow come in?

Sita. Some men of the river found him and picked him up, he says.

Sargon. And what does he say of the phantom that went to Lanka in your stead?

Sita. He says Rama told him it vanished into thin air in Ayodhya.

Sargon. Lanka sounds like a great city, perhaps even equal to Akkad or Ur; and destroyed, all for this...!

Sita. Even though I wasn't there, I feel I share in their disaster.

Sargon. This sailor, was he able to retrieve your husband's body, or –

Sita. No; and I weep for that.

Sargon. So this is why you've torn your hair and your face?

Sita. I loved him; and wherever he is, I still do.

Sargon. Should I believe you? Can I be sure this isn't some trick?

Sita. Would it be easy to deceive your daughter?

Sargon. It's impossible. So... with your husband dead, will you stay a *naditu* in this Temple forever?

Sita. In avoiding you I keep faith with Rama, even beyond the grave.

Sargon. Why taunt me like this? Let the dead man be. Move on with your life, with me! I have a lot to offer you.

Sita. I shall. Prepare for our wedding.

Sargon. Consent was long in coming, but I'm glad.

Sita. We got off on a bad start. Do you know what we should do? Forget the past.

Sargon. On what terms?

Sita. Let us conclude a truce. Give me your friendship.

Sargon. I hereby consign our quarrel to the winds.

Sita. Since you're my friend, I ask you –

Sargon. What would you want of me?

Sita. I wish to... may I bury my dead husband?

Sargon. What, a grave without a corpse? Your people must love shadows. First a phantom was made of you, and now you wish to bury a phantom husband!

Sita. In my country, whenever a man dies at sea and leaves no corpse to burn, the custom is to perform funeral rites with an empty shroud.

Sargon. By all means! Choose any site you wish for your ritual.

Sita. That's not our way of honouring the drowned.

Sargon. What is it, then? I'm quite ignorant of your customs.

Sita. We take the gifts we owe them out to sea.

Sargon. Well how can I help? Do you need grave gifts? I can provide them.

***Rama** stands up and prepares to take part in the dialogue.*

Sita (*pointing to **Rama***). This man knows better than I. He's a sailor, and has performed rites for many of his lost friends.

Sargon (*to **Rama***). Well, stranger, you've brought me welcome news.

Rama. Not welcome to me, nor to the dead man, either.

Sargon. I can imagine – but tell me, how do you bury those who have died at sea?

Rama. It depends on whether they were rich or poor.

Sargon. No expense shall be spared, of course.

Rama. First we offer blood to the powers below.

Sargon. Which animal?

Rama. You choose; it does not matter.

Sargon. In my country, a bull would be customary.

Rama. Just make sure that the animal is flawless.

Sargon. The herds of Sumer and Akkad are full of those.

Rama. We need a bier, too, for the absent body.

Sargon. Consider it given. What else?

Rama. Bronze weapons and armour, bows and javelins especially. The Prince of Ayodhya was a great warrior and marksman.

Sargon. I shall provide them, fit for a King.

Rama. And fruits and flowers, whatever grows native in your country will do.

Sargon. So all this you will give to the sea, as I understand. How will you accomplish this?

Rama. There has to be a boat, with rowers.

Sargon. How far from the land should it go? Only a little way on the river, or all the way to the sea?

Rama. Till the oars can hardly be seen from land.

Sargon. Why all this trouble? What's the purpose of this strange ritual?

Rama. The boat should travel far from land to avoid foul blood being washed back to shore.

Sargon. Very well. A fast vessel is at your disposal, of the sort that can travel the sea as well as the river.

Rama. That's kind of you – and kind to my poor Prince, too.

Sargon. But can't you manage this with a few men, while Sita and I begin our wedding ceremonies? Do you really need her to be there?

Rama. No. The mother, wife, or daughter of the deceased must see it done. It's the core of the entire ritual.

Sargon. You mean, this awful ceremony is her duty, painful as it is?

Rama. To cheat the dead of proper honours is an offense against Justice.

Sargon. I would certainly wish my wife to be pious. She may go. Enter the palace and select your gifts. And select a few for yourself as well; I shall not send you home empty-handed after you helped me win Sita's hand. In place of these rags – for you truly are in a sorry state – you shall have clothes and provisions for your journey. (*To Sita*). And you, unhappy woman: don't weary yourself with tears. Rama is dead, you heard it; crying won't bring him back.

Rama (*to Sita*). You know your task now, lady. Show love to the husband you have, and let the other one go. It's really the best thing to do. If I manage to get back safely to Ayodhya, I'll kill the slanders about you there. Only now that you have a new husband, be the true wife to him that you should be.

Sita. I shall; my lord will have no cause for complaint. But now, poor man, go indoors, take a bath, and change into some clothes. You won't have long to wait for your reward.

*Exit **Sita**, **Rama**, **Sargon**, all into the palace. After a few moments, **Sita** re-enters the stage.*

Sita (to **Chorus**). Friends, things have gone well for us in the palace! The daughter of Sargon, questioned by her father, said not a word of what she knew; indeed, to help me, she confirmed that Rama was dead. Meanwhile, Rama has made a lucky haul; the arms that he was supposed to throw in the sea he's wearing himself, him and his brothers too.

*Enter **Rama** centre stage. He has cast off his rags and wears the reinforced leather cloak and bronze helmet of a Mesopotamian warrior, a bow and quiver slung over his shoulder, a set of javelins at his back.*

Sita. Here he comes, my beloved, once again ready to do battle for my sake as he was at Lanka all those years ago! But this time he fights for the real me, not an illusion made of air. But look out, here comes the proud King who thinks he holds my marriage in the palm of his hand! I must be quiet now. Friends, please, guard your tongues!

*Re-enter **Sargon**, centre. Attended by a retinue of **slaves** bearing gifts for the funeral. The slaves leave the stage right, with their gifts.*

Sargon (to **slaves**). To your work, men. Do as the stranger tells you and take these funeral offerings to the shore. (To **Sita**). Sita, please reconsider. Don't go with that ship. Stay here with me. Whether or not you're on board that boat or not, you've participated in the funeral rites, you honour your husband just the same. It's not that I want to imprison you – you're far too dear to me for that – but I'm afraid that the horror of the whole situation will drive you so mad with grief that you'll throw yourself in the sea. For I have never seen a woman mourn her husband so intensely.

Sita. My new-found husband, I am duty-bound to be on board, to revere the memory of my first marriage. I did love Rama so much that I could die with him, yes – but what good would my death do? He wouldn't want me to die. No, let me go and offer him the gifts he is due. And for your kindness to me and to my poor, dead Rama you shall find me exactly the sort of wife you deserve.

Sargon (to **attendant**). You there, get ready a ship fit for the sea, with a crew of rowers!

Sita (pointing to **Rama**). This stranger is the closest kin Rama had, and will be in charge of the funeral rites. Won't he have command of the ship as well?

Sargon. Yes, he should. My sailors will obey him.

Sita. Repeat that, so they'll all hear.

Sargon. My sailors will obey him. Shall I say it a third time?

Sita. That won't be necessary. Blessings upon your hopes!

Sargon. Now, don't cry too much and spoil your beauty for the wedding!

Sita. O, I will show you today how grateful I am; have no fear of that.

Sargon. Remember, the dead are dust in the Underworld. Tears are wasted effort.

Sita. Indeed, you are right; and I am thinking of my happiness in this world.

Sargon. You will find me as good a man as Rama was, if not better.

Sita. You have been good to me already. Now all I need is good luck.

Sargon. That is yours to choose. I possess every boon the gods could grant. Be with me, and you'll have it.

Sita. I don't need to be taught how to love my friends.

Sargon. Would you like me to accompany you, as support?

Sita. O no. A King should never serve his servants.

Sargon. Very well. I need not bother myself any longer with your Indian ceremonies. My house is clean – it wasn't here that Rama died. (*To attendants*). One of you, go and tell the people of Ur to bring out their wedding gifts. Let the land ring with music and song, in celebration of the marriage between Sita and myself. (*To Rama*). Meanwhile, stranger, put all these things in the sea, in honour of her former husband; but make sure you both hurry back, and share in our wedding banquet. After that, either ail home, or stay here in Ur as long as you like.

Exit Sargon back into the palace. Exit Rama and Sita right, towards the waiting ship.

Chorus. Speed home, o ship, speed home, across the sea's foam as once Urshanabi's vessel carried Gilgamesh back across the waves. There, Sita, you may meet your sisters, your brothers, and their wives beside the sparkling waters of the Sarayu. There, one day, you may learn to celebrate again, learn to join in dance and song.

O to have wings, that I could follow your flight and see you safely home! That I could see the cloud of ill-fame banished, that has shadowed you ever since men's tongues coupled your name in scandal with an enemy's house; the guilt dissolved, which you have borne as punishment for the quarrel at Lanka, even though you never went.

Act V - Betrayal And Reconciliation

Chapter Summary

Sargon realizes he's been betrayed by not only Sita, but his own daughter Enheduanna as well. His bride gone, his sailors killed, Sargon stands ready to kill his own daughter in her Temple; but unexpected resistance from her Sumerian women convinces him to banish her instead.

Enheduanna of Ur is a historical figure, and her banishment from Ur is likewise historical, though it of course happened for different reasons. As in Sita of Ur, the historical Enheduanna also eventually returned to her city, where she appears to have been a very popular figure, remembered and referenced long after her death.

*Enter **Sargon** centre from the palace. A **Messenger** rushes in right, from the shore, and bursts into breathless speech before Sargon has a chance to react.*

Messenger. My lord, I have disastrous news!

Sargon. What is it?

Messenger. You may as well start looking for a new bride. Sita has left the country.

Sargon. Left? On wings, I suppose? Or did she start walking across the water to her home?

Messenger. Rama carried her off in a ship – the very same man who came to bring us report of his own death!

Sargon. That's appalling news! What transport did they use? Did they steal a ship from the river?

Messenger. The ship you supplied him with. Rama went off with your sailors in your ship, like they belonged to him!

Sargon. Unbelievable... How? I want to know how! How could a single man outwit a whole crew? And you were one of them! Why are you standing here, why didn't you die fighting?

Messenger. Yes, I was there, I saw it all happen! When the daughter of Janak was being escorted to the ship, she put on a slow walk and a loud widow's wailing for her husband – all clever acting, for far from being dead, her husband was right beside her! When we reached the dockyard, we hauled out a fine seagoing vessel, complete with benches, oars, and a crew to row it. Each man did his job, and it's quite some work getting a vessel ready for the sea!

While we were thus occupied, some men – they must have been kinsfolk of Rama, bidding their time – approached the dock: fine-looking men, strong, but disheveled and wearing rags just as their Prince had been. Seeing them, Rama pretended not to recognize them but put on a show of sympathy. “Men,” he called, “you have my sympathies! You look like Indian sailors. What ship did you arrive on? Did it get wrecked like mine? Now that you’re here, would you be willing to help your countryman with the burial of Prince Rama of Ayodhya, here at sea? He too was lost, and his wife, the lady Sita here, is honouring her husband with last rites.”

Before we knew what was going on, they’d already come aboard and were carrying various gifts this way and that. Now, we did get suspicious and muttered about these extra passengers, but you’d told us that our guest was to be in command, and he said to let them on. The whole disaster is due to that.

Anyway, the gifts were all pretty light and easily brought aboard, except the bull, who pawed and fought back and wouldn’t allow anyone to touch him. At which point Rama drew a sword from beneath his cloak and shouted, “Men, you have fought rakshasas and prevailed; why can’t you lift up this bull and carry him forward?” They obeyed, seized the bull and manhandled it onto the deck. But with all this, the ceremony had already turned more violent.

At last, Sita sat down on the deck, beside her so-called “dead” husband. The others spread around the ship, hiding swords and spears under their rags without us knowing they were armed. When we had set out down the river onto the sea, and could just barely make out the shore, we asked, “Sir, is this far enough? Should we keep going?” Rama answered, “This is far enough,” and killed the bull over the sea without mentioning any dead man’s name, so that its blood fell into the water and not onto the boat. “May these waves convey me safely,” he said, “back to my native shores, my wife at my side!”

That’s when we knew there was treachery afoot, and one of us shouted, “Make for the shore! Row about to the right!” And Rama’s kinsmen all brought forth swords and spears stolen from I know not where, and set upon us. Our captain fought valiantly, my lord, as did all the rest of your sailors. They did not betray you. We had no weapons, so we broke down benches and planks and struck them with oars from the ship. But Rama and his brothers were too strong. Even with just a few, they were like an army raging through the ship.

Soon, the entire boat was awash with blood.

He left only the helmsman alive, and ordered him to hoist the sail and steer the ship south and east, towards their native shore; and at that moment the wind picked up and blew miraculously in their favour.

And so they’ve escaped from Sumer and Akkad. I only avoided death by climbing down the anchor into the sea, holding my breath until I heard the fighting stop. I was half-dead when a fisherman found me and brought me back to land; and so I give you the news. Healthy mistrust is perhaps not a bad quality, my lord.

Chorus Leader. Rama, here, unknown to you and me? I could never have believed it, my lord.

Messenger exits right.

Sargon. Shame and misery! My bride has escaped, after I finally had a glimmer of hope in my life! If I could overtake them, I'd spare no effort, I'd get them all back and give them what they deserve. But it's no use; with the wind in their favour, they must be far at sea by now. The gods clearly favour Rama today.

As it is, I'll take revenge on my treacherous daughter instead! Enheduanna knows all things. She knew Rama was in my house and she told me nothing. Never again will she cheat men as she has cheated me!

Sargon starts towards the Temple of Nanna, sword drawn; but the Chorus bars his way.

Chorus Leader. Where are you going, my lord? To commit a murder, of your own daughter, and in the Temple precinct no less?

Sargon. I am going where Justice beckons me. Out of my way, Sumerians!

Chorus *(one woman grabs hold of Sargon's cloak).* This is a terrible crime! I won't let you!

Sargon. Does a slave command his master?

Chorus Leader. She's right!

Sargon. But you do me wrong. Let me –

Chorus *(pulling harder on Sargon's cloak).* No!

Sargon. Kill that vile daughter of mine –

Chorus. Pious, not vile!

Sargon. Who betrayed me –

Chorus. She did a good deed!

Sargon. And gave my bride away to some man –

Chorus. Who had first claim! Her own husband!

Sargon *(stops struggling).* First claim, over what's mine? Over a woman who lived in my city, my Empire, for seven years?

Chorus. Her father gave her to him.

Sargon. That was decades ago; her father's dead. Fortune gave her to me, right now.

Chorus. And Fate removed her again. Doesn't that tell you that the gods want Sita to be with Rama, not you?

Sargon. You're no judge of mine, Sumerian woman.

Chorus. I am, if I judge better.

Sargon. So I, Sargon King of the Universe, am overruled by women?

Chorus. You wouldn't be, if you were a just King.

Sargon (*his anger rising*). You all seem in love with death.

Chorus. Kill us then. While we stand here you shall not enter that Temple, and you shall not kill your daughter. Kill us all! She'll know what you're doing and escape; and every woman in this city would gladly die for Enheduanna's sake.

***Hanuman** appears, carried by his father the Wind, above the Temple Gates. He looks down and addresses **Sargon**.*

Hanuman. Sargon, King of Sumer and Akkad, moderate your wrath! It is wrongly aimed. I am Hanuman, son of Vayu the Wind and companion to Rama and Sita, who has now fled your house. Listen to these women; they speak with wisdom.

The lost marriage at which you rage was never meant to be; nor did Enheduanna wrong you when she prevented you from committing an evil deed by murdering Rama and Sita.

It was ordained for Sita to live in your Temple for seven years, as it was ordained for Rama to live in the Forest for fourteen; but after that time, she was meant to return home and share her husband's roof. So sheathe that sword pointed at your daughter, and own that what she did was wise. I would have rescued Sita long ago, were it not that I know destiny, and understand that these things had to be.

(*He turns away from **Sargon** towards the east, towards the sea*). Sail with your husband, Sita; you shall have fair winds. I myself will escort you. And one day, when you complete the course of human life, men of the world to come shall call you divine, and shall honour you for your virtue and your love.

Sargon (*sheaths his sword*). Very well; I will not defile this Temple and my own hands with my daughter's blood. But I cannot abide her keeping secrets from me. Enheduanna is hereby banished from the city of Ur, never to return.

(*To **Chorus***). You women, go tell my daughter to take her belongings and go. Tell her to stay out of my sight.

*The **Chorus** exits left, entering the Temple. **Sargon** exits centre, entering the palace. **Hanuman** vanishes from the top of the Temple Gate. The sun sets, leaving the stage in darkness, as the crickets and insects of the Mesopotamian swamp begin their song.*

*The sun rises over an empty stage. The Temple and palace doors are both closed; only the birdsong of early morning can be heard. The **Chorus Leader** enters, alone, from the Temple.*

Chorus Leader. And so Enheduanna, High Priestess of Ur and First Poet in the world, was banished from our fair city. But what we told Sargon that day was true: all of us women of Ur would gladly die for Enheduanna's sake. Unlike her father, who was distant and imperious, Enheduanna understood the ways of us Sumerians; she understood our language, our gods and our songs, and composed many new songs with us in the Temple.

And so a great outcry broke out among the people of Ur against Sargon, so that he was forced to cease his wars of conquest and turn his army to Ur. But we fought back, in the streets and the alleys and at the riverside; so that finally Sargon, unwilling to destroy his own city and impatient to return to his wars in the west, made peace with his daughter, and asked Enheduanna to return to Ur.

The ways of gods are mysterious, and show themselves in many forms. The gods dispose of many things unexpectedly, and what we are certain should happen, sometimes never takes place.

*The **Chorus Leader** exits stage left, back into the Temple. Birdsong sounds across the stage, in bright sunshine.*

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